

Backup Types

Full, Differential & Incremental - Simple Comparison

What Are Data Backups?

Backups are copies of your data stored separately to protect against data loss from hardware failure, accidents, or disasters.

Full Backup

Copies ALL data every time

What it does:

- Backs up every single file
- Complete copy of all data
- Takes the longest time
- Uses the most storage space
- Provides complete protection

Differential Backup

Copies all changes since last FULL backup

What it does:

- Backs up files changed since last full backup
- Gets larger each day
- Moderate time and storage
- Always references the full backup
- Faster than full, slower than incremental

Incremental Backup

Copies only changes since LAST backup

What it does:

- Backs up files changed since last backup
- Smallest and fastest backup
- Uses least storage space
- Creates a chain of backups
- Requires all backups for full restore

Quick Comparison

Aspect	Full Backup	Differential	Incremental
Speed	Slowest	Medium	Fastest

Storage Used	Most	Medium	Least
Restore Speed	Fastest	Medium	Slowest
Restore Complexity	Simple	Medium	Complex

Remember: Full backup = everything, Differential = changes since last full, Incremental = changes since last backup. Choose based on your storage space, backup time, and restore requirements.

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